

The Myth of the Lernaean Hydra

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Abstract: The Hydra monster lurking beneath the waters of the Halcyon Lake of ancient Lerna, which figured as one of the heroic exploits of Hercules in Greek mythology, was credited with attributes of toxicity and curative regenerative abilities, offering a remarkable prototype for the freshwater invertebrate polyp that resembles its appearance and bears its name in scientific nomenclature. The resemblance, however, is fortuitous since the animal's characteristics are not observable to the unaided eye and it was unknown to the Classical world. The mythical Hydra was a zoomorphism of a psychoactive drug that figured in the very ancient Mystery rites that were still being enacted at the sacred lake well into Roman times, when the original offering of human victims was replaced by initiatory experiences of spiritual transcendence.

Keywords: Mythical Hydra, Hercules Labors, Mystery religion, arrow poison, Philoctetes, alchemical transcendence, sacrificial victim, ergot, Gorgon Medusa. *Amanita muscaria*, shamanism

Essay starts here:

Although there was no fixed canon for the sequence of twelve labors or tasks (the *dodécathlon*) performed by the Greek hero Heracles (Herakles, Latin Hercules), the contest with the female ‘water creature’ or Hydra was often cited as the second. It was thus presented in the sequence of metopes in the decoration of the fifth-century BCE Temple of Zeus at the sanctuary of Olympia in the western Peloponnesus, the original site of the sporting event restored and inaugurated for modern times at the end of the nineteenth

century as the International Olympic Games. The Nemean Lion was generally accorded precedence as the first of the labors since the hero was always distinguished in his iconographic portrayal as wearing its magical pelt, or at least its head, and both the Hydra and the Lion were located topographically near Mycenae, the citadel of Eurystheus, in whose servitude the hero was obliged to perform the tasks. The Nemean Lion was located toward the west in the mountain pass out of the Mycenaean plain, and the Hydra was south along the shore of the plain, and hence both could be considered early in the heroic career of Heracles, as he expanded his scope to more distant sites that would take him as far as Gibraltar and into Africa and also into the northern reaches of Siberia. Just as the Lion provided him with the iconographic emblem of its impervious pelt, the Hydra by all accounts supplied the deadly toxin with which he anointed his arrows. The word 'toxin' is derived from the Greek word for the archer's bow (*tóxon*), and the words for arrow and poison (*iós*) are homophonous in Greek.

Heracles was imagined as belonging to the generation of heroes before the Trojan War, a contemporary of Jason, who sought the Golden Fleece at the far end of the Black Sea, and of Theseus, who was credited with establishing patriarchal descent in the city of Athens and who encountered the Minotaur in the labyrinth of Cretan Knossos. It was Heracles who had placed Priam upon the throne of Troy, and Priam's son Paris who occasioned the War by abducting Helen from Sparta. Heracles was supposedly the son of Zeus, the head of the Olympian family of twelve deities, and all the heroes were engaged in tasks that symbolized the conversion of the world to the mode of male dominant culture brought into the Mediterranean lands by the migration of the Indo-European peoples from their hypothesized homeland in the central Asiatic plateau. In the Indus valley of modern northeast Afghanistan and Pakistan, their language developed into Sanskrit, and in the Balkans, it became Greek. A Celtic branch of this same migration developed into Latin in the Italian peninsula. The establishment of the sanctuary of Olympia was the crowning achievement of Heracles' heroism in that he reassigned it from its previous existence as a place of worship in honor of a goddess to its role as the central shrine to his Olympian father, whose rise to dominance was commemorated in the quadrennial celebration of the Olympian athletic contests. Similarly, the conquest of the Nemean Lion was the etiology for the inauguration of the Nemean Games. Theseus' defeat of Sinis was commemorated

by the Isthmian Games, in his battle with Cercyon at Eleusis, he supposedly invented the sport of wrestling.

The particular supposedly insurmountable attribute of the Hydra that threatened the hero was its ability to regenerate its multiple heads when severed, seven, nine, or fifty, and by some accounts as many as one hundred, each doubling whenever decapitated. Only one of them was mortal, indistinguishable and protected by the others. Heracles could defeat the Hydra only with the help of his nephew Iolaus (Greek Iolāos) by cauterizing the wounds with a torch before each head could regenerate or multiply.

The Hydra was imagined as a gigantic serpent with branching heads, resembling the stem or trunk of some plant with its spreading branches. It also breathed out so foul a sulfurous stench and expelled excrement so noisome that the smell alone would inflict a writhing fit of lethal torment, probably associating it with chthonic subterranean volcanic activity. (Jayne 2003) The sulfurous toxic fumes could kill all the birds within a twenty-mile radius and all the fish swimming in the surrounding waters.

The venom of the Hydra essentially caused a burning sensation. As a dermal agent, it induced an extreme fiery irritation. It could be likened, moreover, to a kind of wine, and hence an intoxicant. This in itself was not unusual since oral toxins and medicinal drugs were generally administered in wine, and wine ordinarily was drunk diluted with three or four parts water, greatly reducing its alcoholic content, but its intoxicating potency was greatly fortified by the addition of variable toxins derived from animal and botanical poisons, including deadly toxins like hemlock in sub-lethal dosages. Some of these were identical with the substances employed as arrow venoms. (Hillman 2008)

When a tuft of wool imbued with the Hydra venom fell by chance into the sunlight on the ground, Heracles' wife Dejanira, who intended to employ it as a love philter to regain her husband's affection, was aghast to notice, as Sophocles in the *Trachiniae* said, that 'it grew warm, melted, and crumbled into pieces, like sawdust from a leveled tree, and from the ground where it lay, a clotted foam seethed up, like a libation of the rich potion from the Bacchic vine.' She unwittingly had anointed a

robe with the toxin and sent it ahead to her returning mate, and when he appears onstage, the robe clings to his sides, like a deadly net, eating away his flesh, like a miasma suffocating his breath, and causing burning pangs of delusional convulsions, like a flower of madness (*manías ánthos*). 'Madness' or mania does not mean insanity, but inspired ecstatic frenzy, often seen as communion with divine forces or superior modes of cognition and knowledge. It was this deadly burning that would culminate in a terminal fiery immolation as spiritual transcendence, burning off his mortal physical remains when Heracles' spirit ascended at the end of his life to the celestial realm through the funeral pyre lit on Mount Oeta, above the thermal volcanic springs of Thermopylae at the base of the mountain. That is the event that awaits him as he is carried away at the end of Sophocles' *Trachiniae* tragedy.

Thereupon, the toxic bow passed into the possession of the tormented hero Philoctetes, whose noisome stench was characterized as the odor of rotting flesh from his gangrenous foot, whose toxins were further intensified by the venomous bite of a sacred serpent on the volcanic isle of Lemnos. His fellow Greeks had abandoned him there as they sailed toward Troy since his fits of madness and noisome stench rendered him a disruptive member of their communal drinking parties. It is this toxic bow with the Hydra's venom that is destined to end the long Trojan War by an arrow delivered to the heel of Paris.

The mountaintop of Heracles' immolation and the holy fire at the core of the volcano on Lemnos establish the axis for spiritual ascendance from the chthonic to the empyreal realms. As the fit of madness overtakes him in Sophocles' tragedy, Philoctetes begs, 'O burn me, please, take me and burn me in this fire of the volcano that I summon. Do for me what I did once for the son of Zeus in exchange for this poisoned bow.' It is thematically significant that the isle of Lemnos was the site of a Mystery sanctuary of the chthonic little Kabeiroi creatures and that the caldera of the volcano there was the forge of the smithy god Hephaestus (Hephaistos), whose name itself means 'volcano' in Greek. In Latin, he is called Vulcanus (Anglicized as Vulcan).

All the monsters encountered by the heroes in their exploits represent zoomorphic materializations for the toxic indwelling spirits of entheogens (plants ‘imbued with deity’), which is to say, magical psychoactive flowers of ecstatic madness or shamanic mania involved as sacraments affording visionary communion with the divine. (Ruck et al. 1979) As with the sanctuary of Olympia, moreover, all the particular sites represent religious shrines whose sanctity the hero’s exploit will reorient toward the honor of the emerging dominance of the Olympian family. The rites enacted at these sites originally required the offering of human sacrifices in which the entheogen played an essential role in preparing the victims to acquiesce in accepting their fate, both as sedatives and also affording a vision of the coming paradise. The hero’s successful completion of his ordeal is signified by his acquiring mastery over the psychoactive agent and by supplanting it with either a symbolic placebo or one associated with the Indo-European tradition, and by the pacification of the ritual sacrifice, often converting it into something mimetic like athletic contests.

All the materialized monsters were toxic, some more identifiably so than others as particular plants. Thus the implausible weapon that Heracles uses to confront the Hydra is a pruning hook, more appropriate for harvesting a botanical item than a proper weapon of warfare. It was such a pruning hook that was also the weapon of choice for the hero Perseus in his decapitation of the Gorgon Medusa, and he placed the plucked head in a *kibisis*, which was a sack slung gaping open upon the arm, recognizable as a harvester’s bag as still employed today for the picking of fruits like the apple. Some ancient accounts and depictions of the scene of decapitation with the pruning hook placed Perseus at the magical Tree of the Golden Apples and equated the plucked Medusa head as both one of those apples and also a psychoactive mushroom, of the type traditionally viewed as a golden red fruit of its host tree, found growing at its base lying on the ground. (Ruck et al. 2011) The mythic paradigm of the heroic quest generally requires the hero not simply to confront the monstrous materialization, but actually to fetch and bring it back to the opponent who had assigned the task. Just as Heracles anointed his arrows with the Hydra’s venom, Perseus employed the severed Gorgon head as his weapon, displaying his mastery of its toxicity by simply removing it from his harvester’s sack and showing it to his enemies.

Heracles sometimes was depicted wielding a club against the Hydra, instead of the harvest implement, or even shooting arrows at it, which some accounts considered the fatal blow. The symbolism, however, is the same, since a club is also a bizarre weapon of warfare, but the particular club of Heracles was pruned from an olive tree on the instructions of the goddess Athena, and hence it was a plant brought against a botanical enemy, on the basis of the common homeopathic belief that the only cure for intoxicated madness was the same toxin that induced the madness. Hellebore, which induces delusionary visions, sometimes interpreted as artistic inspiration, was generally cited as a cure for madness. Molière's doctor who cures madness in *Le médecin malgré lui* (1666) is named Hellebore. In the same way, even the poisoned arrows of Heracles present the same pattern, apart from the logical problem, which is not applicable to the non-linear chronological symbolism of myth, that the hero could not have anointed his arrows with the Hydra's toxins until he had defeated the monster. In the case of the hero Theseus, his weapon of choice was a magical club, made of bronze in the alchemical caldera of a magical volcano like forge of Hephaestus on Lemnos, but so like the real thing that it was indistinguishable from its botanical model, the pruned olive.

The role of the olive in this regard is also traditional and significant, since it was a common motif in the depictions of the various heroes' exploits to include an olive tree at the exact spot where the monster was encountered. Heracles signified the rededication of the Olympian sanctuary by planting the first sacred grove of the tree at the site, and its branches were used to crown the victorious athletes. The olive was emblematic of toxic wild botanical growths that could be pruned from their natural state into a fruiting and productive cultivated transmutation. Olive trees, in fact, require annual pruning to maintain the potential to fruit. The olive was particularly sacred to Athena, which explains her role in providing Heracles with his defining club. The club of Theseus was even more magical since the plant had undergone alchemical transmutation in the caldera of the volcano.

As depicted in vase paintings and art, the Hydra bears a remarkable similarity to the tiny hydra, a multi-cellular freshwater invertebrate polyp, which the Dutch natural scientist Antonie van Leeuwenhoek was the first to name after the mythical prototype in 1702. (Leeuwenhoek 1702-1703) The miniscule animal is now recognized as

potentially immortal, avoiding senescence by continual regeneration, able to grow anew from its severed parts. The hydrozoa are only a few centimeters in length (roughly 10-15 cm, 0.6 inches) and just barely visible to the naked eye, but with the aid of the microscope, Leeuwenhoek noted and drew several of its fundamental characteristics. It is unlikely, however, that the actual hydra animal was ever seen in antiquity and served as the model for the mythical monster, nor do any ancient sources notice its existence. The Swiss naturalist Abraham Trembley, unaware of Leeuwenhoek's precedent, nearly half a century later published his own observations on the freshwater polyp, which he discovered with his two young pupils while acting as tutor for the Earl of Portland's children. (Trembley 1744) In the interim, the Swedish devisor of the system of binomial nomenclature Carl Linnaeus, who made little use of the microscope (Ford 2009), in 1735 had debunked the famous taxidermied remains of the quite sizeable seven-headed monster preserved in Hamburg as a pious fraud, assembled from weasel jaws and feet and the skins of serpents, probably the work of monks attempting to create the beast of *Revelation*. (Linnaeus 1735) Leeuwenhoek's name for the polyp entered the Linnaean system of nomenclature in 1758.

Nevertheless, in addition to the remarkable coincidence of the hydra's appearance and regenerative ability, it presents another fortuitous similarity to the mythical Hydra, with regard to the envenomed arrows of Heracles. The hydra polyp is assigned in the Linnaean scientific nomenclature to the phylum of the *Cnidaria*, named from the Greek *knízein*, 'to nettle or sting,' which includes the jellyfish or 'medusa,' so called in English as early as 1758, and the stinging corals, which according to myth first came into existence from the spilled blood from the severed head of the Medusa. Before submerging into the sea, coral was soft and spongy like a fungus. (Ruck et al. 2012) The Greek verb equally means 'to provoke, tickle, eroticize.' This is another fortuitous coincidence with Dejanira's employment of the Hydra toxin as a love philter or aphrodisiac.

The hydra and other *Cnidaria* actually shoot barbs infected with a paralyzing toxin at their prey. This would certainly have been unobservable in antiquity, at least

in the case of the miniscule hydra, and would appear to be an accidental similarity as the model for the poisoned arrows of Heracles. Since the animal is so tiny, it can cause no harm to humans, although its jellyfish relatives can deliver a lethal sting. With modern technology, the hyaluronidase toxins can be concentrated by ultra-filtration and demonstrate paralytic and other effects similar to certain mushroom and toad toxins. (Sher et al. 2005)

Although these barbs offer a perfect analogue for an arrow, the hydra obviously is not lethal enough to serve as the model for the hero's arrows anointed with the toxin of the mythical Hydra. Nor does the Mediterranean area even provide a suitably deadly water snake to fulfill the role of the Hydra as a freshwater serpent. Even the bite of the moray eel *Muraena Helena*, which generally is native to brackish rather than freshwaters, is not a good candidate. Cooking destroys its toxins and it was considered edible in antiquity. Its deadliness resides in its potential feeding upon human flesh, biting with a clamp-like jaw and draining the blood. Vespasian, a friend of the Emperor Augustus, was said to have fed a slave to his pool of culinary eels as punishment for breaking a crystal cup, and then eaten the eel to taste his revenge. The anecdote was often cited in antiquity as an exemplar of exorbitant luxury and cruelty. The eel's fresh blood, however, remains toxic, and as little as one-tenth of a milliliter per kilogram of prey is sufficient to kill small mammals. These toxins are produced in the serpent's mucous tissues and skin and may aggravate the effect of its bite, but the animal lacks fangs for delivering its toxins effectively.

Inasmuch as the mythical Hydra, however, was a serpent, as such it provides the rationale for its role as the source of Heracles' toxic arrows. The Medusa similarly had vipers for chevelure. Serpents were milked to access their venom as psychoactive toxins, both to serve as arrow poisons, but also as unguents in sub-lethal dosages to access sacred states of ecstasy. The latter is what is implicated in the numerous depictions of women or priestesses handling serpents, dating from the pre-Greek Minoan period of the second millennium BCE through to late Roman times. (Hillman 2013) As a weapon of combat, the arrow's toxin would have to be fast acting. (Mayor 2009) Certain serpents, like the cobra, as well as toads spit their venom at their prey

and offer a more suitable paradigm for a poisoned arrow. Arrows were also dipped in excrement to assure that the wound would fester. Heracles' Hydra toxin, however, is a mythical construct, implying the de-fleshing of material mortality through fiery transcendence to spiritual existence, and it was employed in the transmutation of the world into Olympian ascendancy, and was finally so used in ending the conflict of the Trojan War, whose ultimate agenda was the restoration of Helen to the dominance of her wedded husband Menelaus.

The Hydra monster, however, although a serpent, was a zoomorphism like the Gorgon Medusa of a botanical original. The *kníde* after which the *Cnidaria* are named is the common stinging nettle, *Urtica dioica*. The fifth-century CE lexicographer Hesychius of Alexandria speculated that the verb *knízein* meant that the herb's effect was like a 'bite.' Its many hollow stinging hairs on its leaves and stems offer another intriguing analogue of the toxic arrow and act like hypodermic needles, injecting chemicals that produce a stinging burning sensation, hence its common names as burn nettle, burn weed, and burn hazel. The genus *Urtica* is so named from the Latin verb *urere*, 'to burn,' suggestive of the fiery immolation of Heracles induced by the cloak that Dejanira imbued with the blood of the dying centaur contaminated with the lethal Hydra toxin. The chemicals include serotonin and methyltryptamine hallucinogens, found also in certain mushrooms and toad venoms, and nettles are brewed into alcoholic cordials and country beers to access their psychoactive potential. In all likelihood, however, the nettle's burning sting is another fortuitous coincidence with the Hydra's venom, since the burning induced by the dermal application of its toxin is probably purely symbolic of the transcendence through immolation to the fiery realm of the empyreal paradise of the Olympian deities.

The *kníde* was also identified as the sea nettle (*Actinia equina*) or anemone, which has the same stinging barbs as the hydrazoon, but is large enough to present a likeness to the unaided eye to the multiple heads of the mythical Hydra. Its polypeptide toxins are a possible source for a psychedelic agent similar to LSD. If there was an actual animal after which the Hydra was modeled, it offers an intriguing candidacy.

As Heracles struggled with the mythical Hydra, however, Hera sent a crab to aid the monster. This is a bizarre element in the tale since in no other heroic exploit does the monster have an ally. It is this crab (*kárkinos*) that became the constellation of Cancer. Vase paintings sometimes include the crab in the depictions of the hero's encounter with the Hydra, or even other crustaceans, hence linking the freshwater Hydra with marine creatures like the anemone and corals, and probably also with the metaphor of the Medusa's blood transformed into sponges and coral. It was thought in antiquity that sea crabs turned into scorpions if their claws were removed, and then planted in the ground, from which it sprouted like a plant, with only a single venomous tail in place of its claws. Scorpion venom also offers hallucinatory and lethal potential.

The crab probably figures, however, as an element of the mythical paradigm of single-footed creatures, like autochthonous beings born from the earth. (Lévi-Strauss 1963) Such autochthony implies a botanical identity, sprouted from the earth like a plant, and traditionally such creatures initially have a difficulty in walking. (Lévi-Strauss 1955) It bit Heracles on his foot, which is a motif in a series of maimed, often toxic feet that includes Philoctetes, bitten by the serpent, and Achilles, who will be shot in his heel with an arrow delivered by Paris, who in turn would be shoot in the same way by Heracles' toxic arrow delivered by Philoctetes as the final settlement of the Trojan War. The best know exemplar of such a maimed hero is Oedipus, who is named as the 'swollen foot,' with implications of a phallic identity, found abandoned lying on the mountainside. Mythology offers examples of fungal anthropomorphisms of the single-footed creature as the fantastical tribe of the 'Shade-foots,' who have only a single vigorous leg, with a broad foot, which they use as a parasol when they tire and rest upon their backs, (Ruck 1986) and similarly the 'Cover-mushrooms,' who were little mushroom warriors, using their stipes a spears as they fight beneath the cover of their caps. (Ruck and Staples 1994)

In all probability, however, the vaunted toxin of Heracles' bow is a purely mythical construct derived from the nature of the sacred place where the Hydra was supposedly encountered. Nothing remains today of the Lernaean Alcyonian Lake

except some wetlands just south of the town of Argos along the northeastern coast of the Peloponnese, near the modern village of Mili (*Myloi*). Although in antiquity its depth was without limit and swimmers were dragged down, never to reappear, it silted up into a malarial swamp and was finally drained away in the nineteenth century, although the powerful karstic springs remain, which implies that there were once also accessible subterranean caverns. A karst spring is the termination of a cave system formed where a subterranean river reaches the surface, usually affording access to a vast system of underground chambers. The limestone terrain is similar to the Mexican Yucatán with its sacred *cenotes* or sinkholes, and the tale of the disappeared swimmers probably indicates that the Lernaean Lake was once used for similar rites of human victims. The modern village of Mili (the 'Mills') is named for these springs. Heracles, had he failed, was intended to become one of these sacrificial victims.

The lake and its springs were associated with the myth of the Danaïds, and the waters welling up from its purported hundred wells, represented the futile attempt of the maiden daughters of Danäus to gather water for the nuptials that they had desecrated by murdering their husbands on their marriage night, fifty brides and fifty husbands, equal in number to the supposedly hundred springs at Mili, one for each head of the Hydra by some accounts. The Danaïds had supposedly arrived from Egypt with their father six generations before Heracles, which would be seven generations before the Trojan War and hence in the mid-second millennium BCE, and the controversy that had occasioned the murder of the husbands and the subsequent execution of the maidens involved the essential role of marriage in subjugating the female as subservient to her husband. Thus in fetching the toxin of the female Hydra, Heracles was performing his paradigmatic role in suppressing the power of the goddess and reassigning the cosmos to his Olympian father. Perseus was descended from these Danaïds three generations later and his fetching of the toxic female Medusa head had a similar symbolism, indicated by his subduing into marriage a transmutation of that Medusa in the form of his bride Andromeda.

He sought the advice of the water nymphs as he set out on his quest, which probably implies the Danaïds and that the pathway to the Gorgons was through the karst caverns of the Lerna Lake. Medusa means merely 'queen or female sovereign' of the sisterhood of Gorgons, and the same verbal formation underlies Andromeda as a 'man-sovereign,' descriptive of the Medusa's male or hermaphroditic attribute as bearded, as well as her sovereignty over men. In the underworld, the waters of Lake Lerna welled upwards, either from the sieves that the Danaïds used to gather it or from the leaking urn into which they poured it. All one hundred of the corpses lay down there just beyond the Hydra that was the guardian of the gateway to the chthonic realm of the dead. The maidens were supposedly gathering the water for their prenuptial bath as eternal penance for the matrimonial rite that they had refused, a rite that would have signified their acceptance of a husband's dominance over his wife.

One of the sisters, Hypermnestra, the only daughter of Danäus to survive, accepted her husband, the great-grandparents of Danaë, who was the mother of Perseus as the son of Zeus. The same motif of transition from matriarchy to marriage and patriarchy is indicated in the tradition that the river that fed the karst springs of the Lernaean Lake first flowed from the Danaïd Amymonë, who was abducted, without benefit of matrimony, by the god Poseidon. Although by Classical times, Poseidon was the lord of the oceans, his more ancient persona associated him with sacred springs and freshwater fountains, inasmuch as he was counted an Olympian deity who migrated with Zeus from the Indo-European homeland where there was no ocean, but only rivers and springs. The probable etymology of his Latin equivalent as Neptune associates him with such springs.

The lake's name is a corruption of Halcyon, which despite its pleasant connotations of the 'halcyon days,' which are the brief period of calm seas after the first storms of winter, masks the sinister reality that the halcyon bird supposedly lost her mate in such a storm at sea and the grieving little sparrow was granted respite of a few days, just long enough to lay her eggs safely on the lakeshore, while she lamented her dead husband. She was the mother of the chicks, born with no living

father, and hence they were counted as her offspring in matriarchal fashion. Her mate could be considered as one of the victims sacrificed to the waters of the lake.

The Alcyonian Lake of Lerna was once one of the entrances to the underworld, where the Lernaean Mystery rites, sacred in later times to the Olympian Demeter, were performed. This was the route that Dionysus used when he descended to resurrect his dead mother Semele for her Ascension to Olympus, a myth similar to the Christian Feast of the Ascension or the Assumption of the Virgin or the Orthodox Dormition. The mythic paradigm represents the elevation of the unwedded virginal mother to the celestial realm as the Queen of Heaven (*Regina Coeli*), the bride of her son, who was her former abducting inseminator, as the supreme self-begotten god. (Ruck and Hoffman 2023) This pattern is another instance of the reconciliation with female primacy as subservient to the ultimate dominance of the masculine principle presiding over the universe. The rescue of Semele is also the same celestial transcendence that was afforded by Heracles' mastery over the Hydra's venom as the toxin for his arrows.

The boatman who rowed Dionysus to the middle of the lake on the occasion of his descent to retrieve his dead mother had demanded that the god make love to him as recompense for facilitating his journey, but Dionysus cheated the boatman of his payment by returning by a different route. When the god discovered that in the interim the boatman had died, he ritually fulfilled his promise by fashioning a phallus out of fig wood, which he applied to himself while sitting, grieving like the little halcyon bird, upon the boatman's tomb. The death of the boatman, who was called Polymnos (the theme of 'Many Hymns'), masks the reality of his persona as one of these praiseworthy much hymned victims tossed into the waters, like the poor little halcyon's mate. The eroticism is an indication of the motif of shamanic rapture, which is commonly experienced as cosmic orgasm (Ruck and Hoffman 2012), similarly implied by the flight of the amorous water birds. The murdered husbands, whom the executed Danaïds joined in death, belong to the tradition of human victims of pubescent males offered to the waters of the Hydra's lake.

At the time of the boatman's death, probably dateable to the mid-second millennium BCE, Dionysus, however, had not yet achieved his divine persona as represented among the assemblage of the Olympian family, to which he originally did not belong, and even in later times he was considered somewhat marginal and an outsider, more at home in the chthonic realm of the netherworld. Dionysus, in general, appears to be a latecomer to the Greek pantheon, and although wine drinking is a common theme in the Homeric poems (recorded in writing at the end of the eighth century BCE, but narrating events of the early twelfth century), the god plays no role in the action. His greater antiquity associates him with wild intoxicants, which in the course of his evolution will be transmuted into the inebriating potion manufactured by the subduing of fungal growths into the controlled and civilizing fermentation of yeasts grown on the juice of the grape. This primordial persona, balanced with his patronage of the wine, was essential to his dual symbolism and was repeatedly enacted in the rituals performed in all aspects of his worship. The plant-gathering revels it is generally assumed once involved the sacrificial death of a young male, like the rejected suitors of the Danaïds. This tradition underlies the role of Pentheus in Euripides *Bacchae* tragedy.

The myth of the boatman was the etiology for the wooden phallus as a cultic item in the Mystery enacted at Lake Lerna, and the god's employment of it as a dildo to fulfill his promise to the sacrificed boatman, as he sat on the tombstone mourning, suggests the anal application of the shamanic agent. Since tombstones are not suitable for use as seats, in all probability the tombstone was in the shape of a phallus, or was the dildo itself. The Halcyon myth suggests the same phallic sacred dildo, inasmuch as the erect penis was commonly a metaphoric bird, as amply elaborated in Aristophanes' *Birds* comedy (414 BCE). The dildo was still employed well into the late Roman period for the sacred application of ecstasy inducing toxins, both vaginally and rectally. (Hillman 2013)

Such phallic tombstones were often in the shape more correctly recognized as a mushroom. (Kurtz and Boardman 1971) In fact, 'mushroom' appears to have been a metaphor for the burial coffin or for the tomb itself. "Mushroom" (*mykes*), moreover,

was a common term for an erect penis. In addition, rock-cut monuments as mushroom markers for organized necropolises or cemeteries occur throughout northeastern Greece (Thrace, Macedonia, Bulgaria, Anatolia), mostly in the Late Bronze Age and Early Iron Age (second millennium BCE), with some continuing to operate through the Classical, Hellenistic, and Roman eras. The mushroom marker is often a natural rock formation, sometimes showing signs of human intervention to improve the likeness to the fungus. Further carving in some instances depicts a doorway on the stipe, imparting the sexual metaphor of the vulva as the entrance to the world beyond and the bisexual or hermaphroditic symbolism of the mushroom.

Dionysus even up into the Roman period was summoned from the Lenaeon Lake's depths as *Bougenes*, 'bull-begotten,' with an archaic trumpet, and a lamb was tossed into its waters as an offering to the Keeper of the Gate. The Gorgons were probably also lurking down there along with the Hydra beneath the calm halcyonic watery surface, since they, too, were counted among the other traditional monsters as guardians of the gate to Hades. The site was occupied as early as the fifth millennium BCE. Almost nothing is known about the Mystery, but as a secret mystical rite, it undoubtedly involved a psychoactive sacrament represented as the Hydra zoomorphism. No remains of the Mystery sanctuary survive, probably because the religion was practiced within the system of subterranean caverns.

Dionysus, in fact, was not 'begotten of a bull.' He did, however, materialize in taurine form among the ecstatic revels of his female devotees in mountain rituals of herb gathering, in which the 'bull' was identified as a zoomorphism of the sacred mushroom. As Euripides wrote in his *Bacchae* tragedy: "You seem to be a bull now leading me, and you've grown horns on your head. Were you always a beast, because you certainly have become a bull now?"

The emblem of the thyrsus/narthex, which characterized these revels, was like the *kibisis* of Perseus an implement of herb cutters, so identified by Theophrastus. Mushrooms were thought to bellow like bulls as they burst like autochthonous creatures from the ground. It should be noted also that the Gorgons, who are anthropomorphized zoomorphic visualized versions of these same mushrooms, also

‘mooed’ as the cows that are the mate of the bull, and that this same bellowing was the sound of the thunder whose accompanying lightning flash was the commonly accepted origin for the fruiting mushrooms. (Wasson 1986)

Another mythical tradition about the famous lake of the Hydra at Lerna tends toward this same conclusion and that the visionary sacrament or entheogen of the Mystery rite of the Halcyon Lake partook of the symbolism of wild and cultivated fungal growths. This involves the story about the Proïtids, who by one account were the half-sisters of Perseus. In this version, his father was not Zeus, but Proïtos (Latin Proëtus), after whom the girls were named as his offspring by their mother Stheneboea (Greek Sthenéboia) of the citadel of Tiryns on the shore of the Mycenaean plain.

These maiden half-sisters of Perseus became afflicted with a bizarre mania, which would cause the death of the hero. In matrilineal tradition they might be seen as the daughters, not of their father, but of their mother Stheneboea, who is named for the ‘Strength of the Cow.’ She was also known for her uncontrollable sexual lust, which would eventually cause the death of Bellerophon, who is a double for Perseus from a parallel version of the Medusa tale. (Ruck and Staples 1994) The maidens developed an extreme dermatological deformity, with their skin growing red and scabby characterized with white patches, which was accompanied by the delusion that they were metamorphosing into cows driven madly ecstatic with their sexual lusting for the bull, wandering the mountainside in uncontrollable estrus like maenads or bacchantes, and when they came upon Perseus, they tore him to pieces.

Scholars have assumed that the affliction was scabies, psoriasis, leprosy, or elephantiasis, all of which are purely wild guesses and take no account of the delusion that they were becoming cows in estrus lowing like Gorgons for the erotic communion with the bull and the fact that they were maenads or bacchantes, involved in the plant-gathering rites of the god’s mountain revels. It is ludicrous to imagine the poor girls lugging their deformed leprous or elephantine limbs about the mountainside in a bacchanalian frenzy, or to divorce their bovine delusion from their

sexual longing for the bull-begotten god. The nettlesome itching of their psoriasis required sexual gratification.

The girls were metamorphosing into a metaphor of the sacred mushroom, of the *Amanita* species, characterized by its red cap splotched with white scabs. They were becoming Gorgons. This is borne out exactly by a parallel version of the hero's death which claims that Perseus, thinking that the Gorgon head had lost its power, turned and looked at it. (Ogden 2008) This would mean that the hero who had harvested and tamed the Medusa zoomorphism and its fungal analogue finally succumbed to its deadly potential. Such is the common motif in the tales of the hero and his liminal or dichotomous potential or dual personae, analogous to the fatal recycling of the Hydra toxins back to Heracles, as the hero who had formerly mastered them. (Ruck and Hoffman 2013)

The seer Melampous is credited with curing the maidens by using the waters of the Lerna Lake polluted with the noisome sulfurous stench of the Hydra as a homeopathic agent. The mushroom complex cured the mushroom complex. The Hydra's toxin is the Hydra's medicinal drug.

Melampous has the same name as Molière's Doctor Hellebore. Melampous is named as 'Black-foot,' which is descriptive of the symbolic homeopathic agent that also caused the delusions, since hellebore was also called *melampodion*. Like Oidipous (Oedipus, 'Swollen-foot' or 'Know-foot'), his name suspiciously sounds as though he has but a single foot, like the 'black-foot' herb *melampodion*.

'Black Foot' is the common name for some mushrooms, such as the *Polyporus elegans*, and characteristically, the psychoactive *Amanita muscaria* (often called the 'fairytale mushroom') is pulled from the earth with some black soil still adhering to its bulbous base, yielding a dirty foot. In the folklore of mushrooms, this becomes the black boots of the anthropomorphized little creature. Exemplars range from the popular Santa Claus, now commonly recognized as derived ultimately from the traditions of Siberian reindeer shamanism, to *nain rouge* ("red-dwarf"), a *lutin*, imported from Normandy, that has haunted the region around Detroit, Michigan ever

since the early eighteenth century, and the redcap *powrie*, that inhabits the ruined castles along the border between Scotland and England. All gnomes are said to wear black boots. Fairies, who are now widely recognized as fungal anthropomorphisms, similarly have dirty feet. (Thronn 2007) The lore of the fairies is not confined to the Celtic traditions of the British Isles, but amply documented in Classical antiquity. (Ruck and Larner 2013)

Some claimed that the cure was accomplished at Sicyon, near Corinth, where according to Ovid the aboriginal people first sprouted from the earth as mushrooms that turned into men. Since the delusion that visited the daughters of Proitos was characterized as the lowing of cows for the bull, we should not inquire too closely into the method of administering the gnomish misshapen phallic black-footed antidote.

Dr. Black-foot, however, was no stranger to the sacred dildo. Herodotus credited him with introducing the phallic procession of Dionysus from the Egyptians. In these parades, women carried dolls or puppets about a foot and a half tall, fitted with a penis of about the same length and hinged to bob up and down by the mechanism of attached strings. The Egyptians had an etiological myth for this oversized bobbing member, but the historian, to our loss, declined to convey it.

We should recognize that Melampous never existed, except as a figure in myth, or as a title for a tradition of shamanic priests. There is still another tale about the famous Black-foot seer that suggests that the Mystery of the Hydra's Halcyon Lake partook of the same pattern that is discernable in the Great Eleusinian Mysteries, namely of a transition from the wild mushroom and the offering of human victims to a communal experience of initiation into a shared vision of spiritual transcendence, such as is indicated by the apotheosis of Heracles and by the resurrection of Semele to the celestial empyrean. (Ruck 2006) The tradition of human offerings at Eleusis underlies the plot of Euripides' *Suppliants* tragedy. At Eleusis, the potion for the initiation contained an entheogen derived from ergot, which yields a visionary substance similar to LSD. (Wasson et al. 1976) The participants in the ancient secret

rites practiced in the cavern of the Lernean Hydra well into Roman time obviously did not go there to be offered as victims, but to experience the Herculean transcendence.

Melampous supposedly ruled as king in Argos, which neighbors the nearby Halcyon Lake of Lerna. There are two traditions that connect the famous supposed seer with ergot. In one, he cured a prince of impotence. Seeing his father about to geld a sacrificial offering, the boy ran away, suspecting that he was the intended victim, pursued by his father with the still bloody knife. (Frazer 2933) A gelding knife is usually curved, resembling a pruning hook. Hence it is not difficult to imagine that this is not an historical event, but a sacred etiology with botanical implications. In fact, by one account, the father wasn't gelding rams, but using the knife to prune trees. The father, to calm his son's suspicion, tossed the bloody knife aside, by chance lodging it in a tree, which according to some accounts, was no ordinary tree, but a sacred tree, whose indwelling deity in consequence had cursed the boy. It might have been the same sacred oak that stood in front of the house of Melampous and harbored a brood of serpents, from whom the seer was said to have received his shamanic powers. The serpents imply something toxic and psychoactive associated with the tree, since it empowered the shaman, and the species as an oak obviously partakes of the sanctity of that tree in Druidic traditions. The episode of the gelding-pruning knife and the boy's anxiety probably masks the fact that he was indeed the intended victim, not for castration, but as a human offering.

As a shaman, Melampous could speak with birds. A vulture told him of the incident with the gelding-pruning knife, and when it approached the tree, it told the black-footed hellebore shaman the cure. He was to remove the knife from the tree's trunk, boil it, and give the boy the rusty water in wine to drink, wine being the customary mode of administering drugs. The sacrificial knife that rusted in the oak represents the transition from the Druidic sacred tree that is host to the parasitic mistletoe and the *Amanita muscaria*, linked in symbolism and sanctity, to the cultivated psychoactive agent derived from rust.

One of the common names for ergot in Greek, as in English, was 'rust' (*erysíbe*). It served also as an epithet of the goddess of the Eleusinian Mystery. It is descriptive of the color, but implies as well the metaphor of the rusting of iron, which signifies the reversion of the manufactured metal back to the primitive ore from which it was extracted. Hence it is a symbolic mediation between the dichotomy between the wild and the cultivated antitheses. The ergot-infested kernels of barley, in fact, appear to provide a seed for the otherwise seedless growth of mushrooms, since as with all fungi, the mycelium under suitable conditions of moisture sprouts into the fruiting bodies, recognizable as mushrooms to the unaided eye.

A similar tale of rust as a cure was told about Telephus, a son of Heracles. The story of his infancy displays all the mythical motifs that would identify him with the attributes of fungal consubstantiality. He had received a wound from the spear of Achilles that would not heal, and the oracle at Delphic advised that what had caused the wound would be its cure. The cure for the incurable wound of Telephus was the rust scraped from the blade of the magical spear of Achilles. This weapon, like the club of Theseus, was no ordinary blade, but had been forged in the volcanic caldera of the god Hephaestus. The tale was the subject of tragedies by both Sophocles and Euripides. Pliny interpreted the cure not as sympathetic magic, but assumed that there was some kind of homeopathic remedy involved. Scholars have commented on his naïveté, but in reality we might have assumed that Achilles would not let his blade rust, or that the workmanship of the volcanic smithy might have produced a weapon not susceptible to corruption.

The other tradition involves Melampous with King Midas. The ergot kernels suggest another metaphoric description as 'ass's ears.' (Ruck et al. 1011) As king of Phrygia, Midas wore a Phrygian cap, which is perhaps the most ubiquitous representation of the *pileus* or 'cap' of the *Amanita muscaria* and its involvement in the myth of Perseus and in the symbolism of Mithraism and the secret initiatory societies derived from it. Midas judged the famous musical contest between Apollo and the satyr Marsyas. The presence of the satyr obviously implies the theme of a bacchanalian revel. When the king judged the satyr victor, Apollo called him an ass

and gave him ass's ears, which the ashamed king kept hidden beneath his Phrygian cap, which is to say, his Amanita hat. Only the barber knew, since the king would have to remove his cap for his haircut, but he was sworn to secrecy.

The secret proved more than the barber could bear. As Ovid told the story, he dug a hole by the banks of the Pactolus River and shouted his secret into the ground and then buried it. Unfortunately reeds grew from the secret burial site and as the wind blew through them rustling, they whispered that the king had ass's ears. The rustling reeds, of course, are like the sheaves of grain bearing their infestation of ergot. This was the same river, moreover, where the king washed away his notorious affliction that turned all that he touched to gold. It is another case of homeopathic therapy, and the golden touch is probably metaphoric for alchemical transmutation and the primordial analogue of the ergot fungus.

Although the Hydra provided a very fortuitous name for the hydra hydrozoa, its mythical construct in antiquity derives from the same sacred botanical lore that surrounded the other stinging *Cnidaria*, the Medusa and her children.

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